Question:

What led to the development of Modernization theory back in the 1940s and 50s? Describe at least 4 critiques of Modernization theory.

Answer

Modernization theory developed mainly in the 1940s and 1950s, especially after the Second World War. During this period, the powerful Western countries started to think that developing countries were poor because they were traditional, backward and lacked modern science, technology, industry and capitalist values.

The main idea of modernization theory was that developing countries should follow the same path of development that Western countries had followed. According to this theory, development means moving from a traditional society to a modern society. A traditional society is based on agriculture, subsistence farming, barter system, kinship ties and old cultural values. A modern society is based on industrialization, science, technology, specialization, market economy, technical skills and mass production.

One important reason behind the rise of modernization theory was the post-war global situation. After World War II, Western countries wanted to spread their scientific and industrial progress to poor countries. They presented this as development assistance. The old form of colonialism was no longer acceptable, so the language of “development”, “aid”, “modernization” and “progress” became important.

Modernization theory also developed from the capitalist belief that economic growth and industrialization would solve poverty. It believed that developing countries could become rich if they adopted Western technology, Western education, modern agriculture, industries and modern values.

Another reason was the colonial and Eurocentric view of developing countries. Western countries believed that they were advanced and civilized, while developing countries were backward and needed guidance. Therefore, modernization theory placed the responsibility of developing poor countries in the hands of rich countries.

The theory also became popular because it gave a simple linear model of development. It argued that every society passes through fixed stages, from traditional society to take-off, industrial growth, maturity and finally mass consumption. In this way, modernization theory suggested that developing countries only needed to copy the Western model in order to develop.

However, modernization theory has many serious criticisms.

1. Modernization theory is Eurocentric

The first major criticism is that modernization theory is Eurocentric. It assumes that Western countries are the model of development and that developing countries must follow the same path. This is problematic because it treats Western culture, technology and values as superior, while treating the culture and knowledge of developing countries as inferior.

Modernization theory ignores the fact that developing countries had their own history, knowledge, skills, economic systems and social organizations before colonial rule. These societies were not completely backward or empty. They had agriculture, trade, craft production, medicine, art, political systems and local technology.

Therefore, modernization theory wrongly presents development as something that must come from the West. It does not respect the internal capacity of developing countries to develop according to their own culture and historical conditions.

2. Modernization theory oversimplifies development

The second criticism is that modernization theory gives an oversimplified view of development. It presents development as a straight line from traditional society to modern society. According to this view, all countries must pass through the same fixed stages.

But in reality, development is not so simple. Countries do not always move forward smoothly. War, political conflict, natural disasters, economic crisis, disease and external pressure can push countries backward. A country may develop in one sector but remain weak in another sector.

For example, a developing country may have agriculture, industry and tourism at the same time. So it is not easy to place a country neatly into one stage of development. The modernization model is too theoretical and does not fully explain the complex realities of developing countries.

Thus, modernization theory is weak because it ignores the ups and downs of real development.

3. Modernization theory is top-down and ignores the poor

The third criticism is that modernization theory follows a top-down approach. It assumes that development should be planned by governments, elites, foreign experts or rich countries and then imposed on poor people.

This is a serious weakness because the poor people, who are supposed to benefit from development, are not placed at the centre of the process. Their needs, creativity, local knowledge and participation are ignored. As a result, development becomes an imposed programme instead of a people-centred process.

When development policies are made without involving the target community, people may not support them. Such policies often fail because they do not understand the real social, cultural and economic conditions of the people.

Therefore, modernization theory treats poor people as passive receivers of development, not as active participants in their own development.

4. Modernization theory destroys local culture

The fourth criticism is that modernization theory leads to cultural destruction. It argues that developing countries must abandon their traditional values and adopt modern Western values. In this way, development becomes connected with the loss of local culture and identity.

This is a problem because culture is not always an obstacle to development. Local values, community life, cooperation, indigenous knowledge and traditional skills can also support development. But modernization theory often presents these things as backward.

As a result, people in developing countries may begin to reject their own values and depend on foreign ideas. This creates mental dependence and weakens the confidence of local people.

Therefore, modernization theory is criticized because it promotes deculturalization. It does not allow developing countries to build development on their own cultural foundation.

5. Modernization theory is externally driven

Another criticism is that modernization theory gives too much importance to external forces. It assumes that developing countries cannot develop by themselves and must depend on rich countries for capital, technology, knowledge and planning.

This makes developing countries dependent on foreign aid, foreign experts, foreign technology and foreign institutions. Many development programmes are prepared outside the country and then sent to developing countries for implementation.

The problem is that such programmes often ignore local realities. They may not fit the social, political, cultural and economic situation of the country. Because of this, many externally imposed development policies fail.

Thus, modernization theory weakens self-reliance and gives rich countries the power to decide the development path of poor countries.

6. Modernization theory creates dependency and exploitation

Modernization theory claims that rich countries help poor countries to develop. But in reality, this help often comes with conditions. Aid, loans, technology and development programmes may benefit the rich countries more than the developing countries.

Developing countries are often encouraged to produce raw materials, while rich countries produce finished industrial goods. This creates an unequal relationship. Poor countries sell cheap raw materials and buy expensive manufactured goods. As a result, the rich countries continue to become richer, while developing countries remain dependent.

Technology also becomes a tool of control. Developing countries depend on rich countries for machines, skills, patents and scientific knowledge. This prevents them from becoming fully independent.

Therefore, modernization theory is criticized because it does not remove dependency. Instead, it can deepen economic exploitation.

Conclusion

In conclusion, modernization theory developed after World War II because Western countries wanted to spread their model of development to developing countries. It was based on capitalism, industrialization, science, technology and the belief that poor countries should follow the path of Western countries.

However, the theory has many weaknesses. It is Eurocentric, oversimplified, top-down, culturally destructive, externally driven and creates dependency. It fails to understand that developing countries have their own history, culture, knowledge and capacity for development.

Therefore, development should not simply mean copying the West. True development should be people-centred, locally based and connected with the values, needs and realities of developing countries.

Question:

Rostow Model presented the five classic stages of economic development which every country must pass through. However, the dependency theorists argue that Rostow's model is not only largely 'Eurocentric', it also ignores the historical economic realities of the west. Explain.

Answer

Rostow's model is one of the most important models of modernization theory. It presents development as a linear process through which every country must pass in order to become developed. According to this model, all countries move from a traditional stage to a modern industrial stage. It assumes that the path followed by Western countries is the natural and universal path of development for all countries.

Rostow divided economic development into five classic stages.

First is the **traditional society**. In this stage, the economy is mainly based on subsistence agriculture, barter system, low technology and limited production.

Second is the **pre-condition for take-off**. In this stage, specialization begins, surplus production increases, trade expands and transport infrastructure is developed. Savings and investment also become important.

Third is the **take-off stage**. In this stage, industrialization begins to increase and the economy starts moving from agriculture to manufacturing.

Fourth is the **drive to maturity**. In this stage, the economy becomes more diversified. New industries develop and the country becomes less dependent on imports.

Fifth is the **age of mass consumption**. In this final stage, the economy becomes fully modern. Mass production increases, the service sector expands and people enjoy a higher standard of living.

At first sight, this model seems simple and attractive because it gives developing countries a clear path to follow. But dependency theorists strongly criticize this model. They argue that Rostow's model is not only Eurocentric, but it also ignores the real historical economic relationship between developed and developing countries.

1. Rostow's model is Eurocentric

The first major criticism is that Rostow's model is Eurocentric. It takes the experience of Western countries as the standard model of development and assumes that every country must follow the same path.

According to this view, Western countries are presented as modern, advanced and successful, while developing countries are presented as traditional, backward and undeveloped. This is problematic because it treats Western development as universal and superior.

Dependency theorists argue that developing countries cannot simply copy the Western path because their historical experience is different. Western countries developed under particular historical conditions, including colonial expansion, control over resources, industrial capitalism and domination over other regions.

Therefore, Rostow's model wrongly assumes that what happened in the West can automatically happen in developing countries. It does not recognize that developing countries have their own history, culture, social structure and economic realities.

Thus, the model is Eurocentric because it places the West at the centre of development and treats developing countries as if they are just late versions of Western countries.

2. It ignores the colonial history of developing countries

The second criticism is that Rostow's model ignores the history of colonialism. It presents developing countries as if they are naturally poor or simply stuck in the traditional stage. But dependency theorists argue that underdevelopment is not natural. It was historically created through colonial exploitation.

During colonial rule, developed countries did not allow developing countries to develop independently. Instead, they controlled their land, labour, raw materials and markets. The economies of developing countries were reorganized to serve the interests of the developed countries.

This means that developing countries were not simply "behind" in the stages of development. Rather, their development path was interrupted and distorted by colonialism.

Rostow's model fails to explain this reality. It assumes that developing countries are poor because they have not yet passed through the correct stages. But dependency theorists argue that they are poor because their resources and labour were used for the development of the West.

Therefore, the model ignores the historical fact that the development of the West and the underdevelopment of developing countries are connected.

3. It ignores how the West actually developed

The third criticism is that Rostow's model gives a false picture of how Western countries became developed. It suggests that Western countries developed through internal savings, investment, industrialization and modernization.

But dependency theorists argue that this is only half of the story. The West did not develop only through its own internal efforts. It also developed by extracting wealth from developing countries.

During colonialism, raw materials, minerals, agricultural products, cheap labour and profits were taken from developing countries and transferred to developed countries. These resources helped Western countries to build industries, accumulate capital and expand their economies.

In other words, the West’s “take-off” was not simply a natural internal stage. It was supported by external exploitation.

Rostow’s model ignores this historical economic reality. It presents Western development as clean, natural and self-generated, while hiding the role of colonial extraction and unequal exchange.

Therefore, dependency theorists argue that Rostow’s model is misleading because it does not explain the real source of Western wealth.

4. It assumes all countries start from the same position

Another major criticism is that Rostow’s model assumes that all countries begin from the same starting point. It suggests that every country is standing at a particular stage and can move forward if it adopts the right policies.

But dependency theorists argue that developed and developing countries do not start equally. Developed countries already have capital, technology, industries, strong institutions and control over the global market. Developing countries, on the other hand, have suffered from colonialism, resource extraction, weak industrial base, debt, unequal trade and dependency.

So it is unfair to say that developing countries are simply at the “traditional stage.” Their situation is not just a matter of being late. Their underdevelopment was produced by an unequal global economic system.

Therefore, Rostow’s model is weak because it ignores unequal power relations between developed and developing countries.

5. It ignores dependency between the centre and periphery

Dependency theorists argue that the world economy is divided into the **centre** and the **periphery**. The centre means the developed countries, and the periphery means the developing countries.

The relationship between them is not equal. Developed countries control technology, capital, markets and political power. Developing countries provide raw materials, cheap labour and markets for finished goods.

This creates dependency. Developing countries depend on developed countries for aid, loans, technology, machines, experts and manufactured goods. At the same time, developed countries depend on developing countries for cheap raw materials and labour.

Rostow's model does not discuss this relationship. It treats development as an internal process within each country. It does not show how the global economy keeps developing countries dependent.

Therefore, dependency theorists criticize Rostow because his model ignores the centre-periphery relationship that keeps poor countries poor and rich countries rich.

6. It ignores unequal trade

Another important criticism is that Rostow's model ignores unequal trade between developed and developing countries.

Developing countries are often forced to export raw materials and import finished manufactured goods. Raw materials are usually sold at low prices, while manufactured goods are sold at high prices. As a result, developing countries earn less but spend more.

For example, a developing country may export minerals, cotton, cocoa, coffee or oil at a low price, but later import machines, vehicles, medicines or technology at a much higher price.

This unequal exchange benefits developed countries and keeps developing countries in a weak economic position.

Rostow's model does not explain this problem. It simply says that developing countries should industrialize and move to the next stage. But it does not explain why the international trading system prevents many developing countries from industrializing properly.

Therefore, dependency theorists argue that Rostow's model is incomplete because it ignores the unfair structure of world trade.

7. It ignores the role of foreign aid and conditionalities

Rostow's model also supports the idea that developed countries can help developing countries through aid, investment, technology and expert advice. This sounds positive, but dependency theorists argue that foreign aid often comes with conditions.

These conditions may force developing countries to follow policies designed by developed countries or international institutions. Sometimes these policies do not fit the social, political and economic realities of developing countries.

As a result, development becomes externally controlled. Developing countries lose the freedom to choose their own development path. Their policies are shaped by the interests of powerful countries.

Thus, what is presented as “help” can become another form of control.

Dependency theorists therefore argue that Rostow’s model is weak because it does not question the power behind foreign aid, loans and externally imposed development policies.

8. It presents development as too simple and linear

Rostow’s model is also criticized because it presents development as a simple straight line. It assumes that countries move from one stage to another until they reach mass consumption.

But in reality, development is not so smooth. Countries may move forward in one period and backward in another. War, political instability, natural disasters, debt, global economic crisis and external interference can stop or reverse development.

Also, a country may have agriculture, industry and services at the same time. So it is not always possible to place a country neatly into one stage.

Therefore, Rostow’s model is too theoretical. It oversimplifies the complex reality of economic development.

Dependency theorists argue that development cannot be understood only through internal stages. It must be understood through historical exploitation, global inequality and the unequal relationship between developed and developing countries.

9. It blames developing countries for their poverty

Another criticism is that Rostow’s model indirectly blames developing countries for their own poverty. It suggests that they are poor because they are traditional, lack modern values, lack savings, lack technology and have not yet reached the take-off stage.

But dependency theorists argue that this explanation is unfair. Developing countries are not poor simply because of internal weakness. They are poor because their resources, labour and markets have been historically controlled by developed countries.

By ignoring this, Rostow’s model hides the responsibility of developed countries in creating underdevelopment.

Therefore, dependency theorists argue that poverty is not only an internal problem. It is also the result of external domination and historical exploitation.

Conclusion

In conclusion, Rostow's model presents development as a five-stage linear process from traditional society to mass consumption. It argues that every country must pass through these stages in order to become developed.

However, dependency theorists strongly criticize this model. They argue that it is Eurocentric because it treats the Western path as the universal model of development. It also ignores the historical economic realities of the West because Western development was not achieved only through internal savings and industrialization. It was also built through colonialism, exploitation, unequal trade, extraction of raw materials and control over developing countries.

Therefore, developing countries cannot simply follow Rostow's stages and expect to become developed. Their underdevelopment must be understood in relation to the historical and continuing domination of the global economic system. True development requires breaking dependency, reducing external control and allowing developing countries to build their own development path according to their own realities.